The Land Buyer's Checklist

12 things to check before you buy the lot

Before you fall in love with a lot, check these.

- [ ] **1. Perc test and septic feasibility**
  Have the lot perc-tested before you buy, not after. A failed perc test can kill a build or force a $40K+ engineered system. Ask the seller if a test has ever been done.

- [ ] **2. Well water: depth and quality**
  Ask neighbors about their well depth and water quality. Deep wells cost more to drill. Iron or sulfur in the water means filtration systems.

- [ ] **3. Zoning and setbacks**
  Confirm the lot is zoned for what you want to build. Check setback requirements, they determine where the house can actually sit. Some towns have ridgeline or viewshed rules.

- [ ] **4. Wetlands and floodplain**
  Check federal and state wetland maps, then walk the lot after rain. Wetlands restrict where you can build and add permitting time. A cheap lot with wetlands is not a cheap lot.

- [ ] **5. Driveway access and road frontage**
  Confirm legal access. Landlocked parcels or shared driveways without recorded easements are deal-breakers. Long driveways cost $15K to $60K to build.

- [ ] **6. Utilities: electric distance**
  Call the power company and ask what it costs to run electric to the build site. If the nearest pole is 500 feet away, that's real money.

- [ ] **7. Survey and title**
  Get a current survey. Confirm acreage, boundaries, and any easements or rights-of-way crossing the lot.

- [ ] **8. Cell service and internet**
  Non-negotiable for remote work. Test it on the lot with your own phone. Ask about fiber or fixed wireless availability.

- [ ] **9. Taxes and school district**
  Sullivan County taxes vary significantly by town. Know the number before you buy, it affects your monthly cost for decades.

- [ ] **10. The view at different times of day**
  Visit morning and evening. A western exposure means sunset views and hot afternoons. Southern exposure means light all day.

- [ ] **11. Neighbors and future development**
  Ask what's around you and what could be built next door. Check for subdivision activity nearby.

- [ ] **12. Resale logic**
  Even if this is your forever home, buy a lot someone else would want. Good lots hold value. Odd lots with problems do not.

THE BOTTOM LINE

The right lot makes the build easy. The wrong lot makes it expensive. If you want a second set of eyes on a parcel before you commit, that's a conversation worth having.

Want a second set of eyes on a parcel? **845-747-0244** / **info@corestonedevelopers.com** / **corestonedevelopers.com**